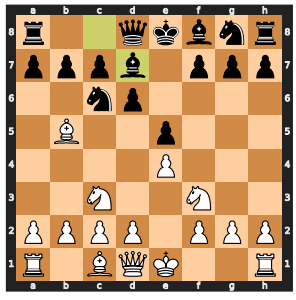
Game 13



Ruy Lopez

Morrison – Capablanca

New York, 1918

White: J. S. Morrison Black: J. R. Capablanca

Notes by J. R. Capablanca, from Chess Fundamentals *(1921), which is in the public domain.*
Descriptive notation has been converted to algebraic. Page references are to the book.
Click any move or diagram to open it on Lichess.

1.e4 e5 2.♘f3 ♘c6 3.♗b5 d6 4.♘c3 ♗d7 5.d4 exd4 6.♘xd4 g6

In this form of defence of the Ruy Lopez the development of the King's Bishop via g7 is, I think, of great importance. The Bishop at g7 exerts great pressure along the long diagonal. At the same time the position of the Bishop and Pawns in front of the King, once it is Castled, is one of great defensive strength. Therefore, in this form of development, the Bishop, we might say, exerts its maximum strength (Compare this note with the one in the Capablanca-Burn game at San Sebastian, page 197.)

7.♘f3 ♗g7 8.♗g5 ♘f6

Of course not 8...♘ge7; because of 9.♘d5. The alternative would have been 8...f6; to be followed by ♘ge7; but in this position it is preferable to have the Knight at f6.

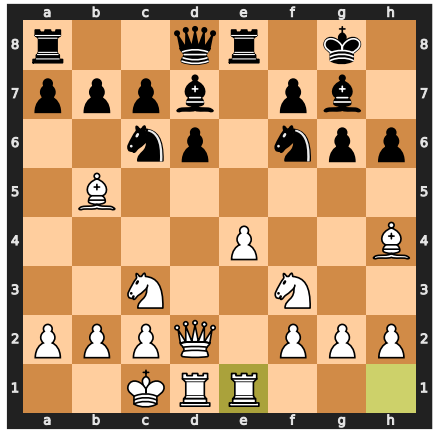
9.♕d2 h6 10.♗h4

An error of judgment. White wants to keep the Knight pinned, but it was more important to prevent Black from Castling immediately. 10.♗f4 would have done this.

10...0–0 11.0–0–0

Bold play, but again faulty judgment, unless he intended to play to win or lose, throwing safety to the winds. The Black Bishop at g7 becomes a very powerful attacking piece. The strategical disposition of the Black pieces is now far superior to White's, therefore it will be Black who will take the offensive.

11...♖e8 12.♖he1



White wanted to keep his Queen's Rook on the open file, and consequently brings over his other Rook to the centre to defend his e-pawn, which Black threatened to win by ...g5, followed by ♘xe4.

12...g5!

Now that the King's Rook is in the centre,

Black can safely advance, since, in order to attack on the King's side, White would have to shift his Rooks, which he cannot do so long as Black keeps up the pressure in the centre.

13. ♗g3 ♘h5

Uncovering the Bishop, which now acts along the long diagonal, and at the same time preventing e5, which would be answered by ♘xg3; Pawn takes Knight, ♘xe5; etc., winning a Pawn.

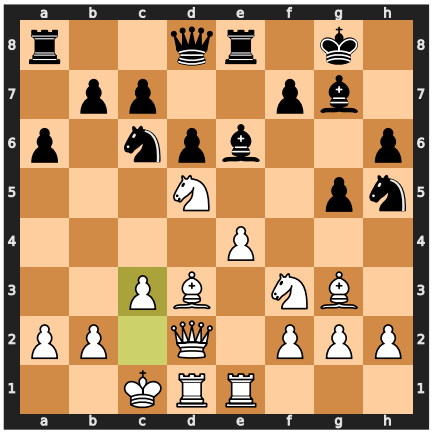
14. ♘d5 a6

Black drives the Bishop away so as to *unpin* his pieces and be able to manoeuvre freely.

15. ♗d3 ♗e6

Preparing the onslaught. Black's pieces begin to bear against the King's position.

16.c3



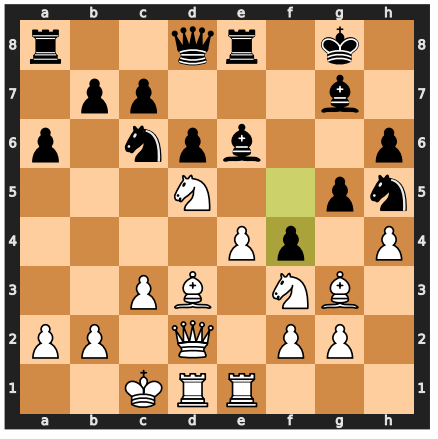
With the last move White not only blocks the action of Black's King's Bishop, but he also aims at placing his Bishop at b1 and his Queen at c2, and then advancing his e-pawn, to check at h7.

16...f5!

Initiating an attack to which there is no reply, and which has for its ultimate object either the winning of the White Queen's Bishop or cutting it off from the game. (Compare this game with the Winter-Capablanca game at Hastings.)

17.h4 f4

The Bishop is now out of action. White naturally counter attacks violently against the seemingly exposed position of the Black King, and, with very good judgment, even offers the Bishop.



18.hxg5! hxg5!

Taking the Bishop would be dangerous, if not actually bad, while the text move accomplishes Black's object, which is to put the Bishop out of action.

19. ♖h1 ♗f7 20. ♔b1

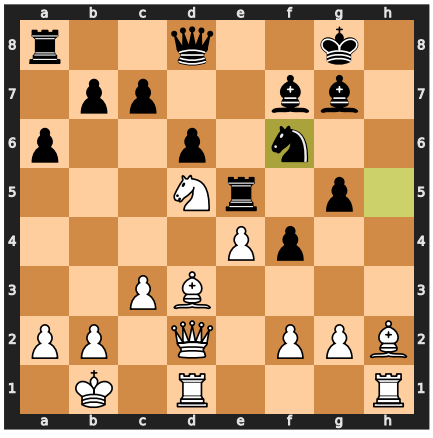
This move unquestionably loses time. Since he would have to retire his Bishop to h2 sooner or later, he might have done it immediately. It is doubtful, however, if at this stage of the game it would be possible for White to save the game.

20...♘e5 21. ♘xe5 ♖xe5

It was difficult to decide which way to retake. I took with the Rook in order to have it prepared for a possible attack against the King.

22. ♗h2 ♘f6

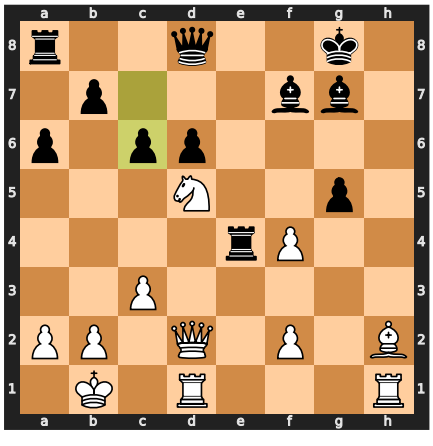
Now that the White Bishop has been driven back, Black wants to get rid of White's strongly posted Knight at d5, which blocks the attack of the Bishop at f7. It may be said that the Knight at d5 is the key to White's defence.



23.g3

White strives not only to have play for his Bishop, but also he wants to break up Black's Pawns in order to counter-attack. The alternative would have been 23.♘xf6+ ♕xf6; and Black would be threatening ♖h5, and also ♕e6. The student should notice that Black's drawback in all this is the fact that he is playing minus the services of his Queen's Rook. It is this fact that makes it possible for White to hold out longer.

23...♘xe4 24.♗xe4 ♖xe4 25.gxf4 c6



26.♘e3

26.♘b4 was the alternative, but in any event White could not resist the attack. I leave it to the reader to work this out for himself, as the variations are so numerous that they would take up too much space.

26...♕a5 27.c4 ♕xd2 28.♖xd2 gxf4 29.♘g4 ♗g6

This forces the King to the corner, where he will be in a mating net.

30.♔a1 ♖ae8

Now at last the Queen's Rook enters into the game and soon the battle is over.

31.a3

If 31.♖xd6 ♖e1+ 32.♖d1 ♖1e2.

31...♖e1+ 32.♖xe1 ♖xe1+ 33.♔a2 ♗f7 34.♔b3 d5

the quickest way to finish the game.

35.♗xf4 dxc4+ 36.♔b4 c3 37.bxc3 ♖e4+ 38.c4 ♖xc4+ 39.♔a5 ♖xf4 40.♖d8+ ♔h7 41.♖d7 ♗e6

Resigns.

A very lively game.